



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Emmaus Academy
School Website: <https://emmausacademy.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Emmaus Academy IL 61101 presents a robust classical Christian orientation, with clear emphasis on the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), living books and Habits-based formation, and a distinctive partnership model that actively involves parents in the educational formation of their children. Public materials consistently articulate a mission of pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty within a Christian framework, and the school foregrounds virtue, character formation, and wisdom as central aims of education. The curriculum and pedagogy showcase classical elements (grammar-logic-rhetoric, memory work, nature study, picture study, composer study, Shakespeare) alongside Charlotte Mason influences (living books, habit formation, at-home/onsite blend). There is explicit language about a Christian curriculum centered on Christ, with governance and faculty explicitly professing Christian faith. Across six classical criteria, Emmaus Academy demonstrates a substantially classical orientation, with little evidence of the negative signals that typically accompany non-classical approaches.

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
- Core supporting cues: Trivium-based curriculum, living books, memory work, nature study, Shakespeare, composer study, and a Christian, liturgical-inflected community life. Strong signals of formation over mere information, and a deliberate partnership model with parents.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials present Emmaus as a Christian classical educator: "Emmaus Academy exists to walk with families along the path of classical Christian education, passionately pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty on the journey from wonder to Wisdom." - Distinctives explicitly mark a Christian orientation: "CENTERED ON CHRIST" and "CHRISTIAN" in the school's stated distinctions. - Governance and faculty explicitly profess faith in Jesus Christ: "As a Christian organization, all board, faculty, and staff profess faith in Jesus Christ." - The site references the Paideia of the Lord and the Liberal Arts Tradition, linking curriculum to theological formation and virtue.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; Christ; Word of God; liturgy/worship cues (Soli Dei gloria); reverence/wonder; logos/wisdom; imago Dei; paideia. The public materials surface direct uses of truth/goodness/beauty, virtue, theology, and Christ-centered language repeatedly. - Negative keywords: none identified in public materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: ~15 - Negative keywords identified: 0 - Estimated ratio: 15:0, i.e., essentially fully positive - Why this rating: The school's public materials foreground transcendental goods (truth, goodness, beauty), a theology-centered pedagogy, and a Christ-centered community, aligning squarely with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations criterion. The absence of negative signals further supports a CLASSICAL classification. Supporting texts include statements about "Christian education," "Center on Christ," and the board/faculty professing faith in Jesus Christ.

Why this rating - The materials place religious/metaphysical aims front and center, with explicit theology and liturgical-tinged community life (Soli Deo gloria and Christ-centered language). The positive keyword set is broad and reinforced by governance and curriculum language. This meets the transcendental moral realism, grounded theology, and liturgical/community indicators in the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Core mission emphasizes formation toward virtue and wisdom beyond job-readiness: “pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty on the journey from wonder to Wisdom” and a formation-oriented framing. - The public materials foreground lifelong formation and the pursuit of human flourishing, not merely workforce preparation. The “Common Goal” and related posts repeatedly frame education as a formation of character/habits and the cultivation of wisdom. - The school explicitly uses classical aims (paideia, liberal-arts orientation) in describing its mission and pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; telos; pursuit of true/good/beautiful; scholé; contemplation; lifelong learning; human excellence. - Negative keywords: none evident in public materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: ~9 - Negative keywords identified: 0 - Estimated ratio: 9:0 (essentially all positive) - Why this rating: The materials consistently describe formation as the primary telos of education and emphasize virtues and wisdom as central aims, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for School Purpose and Goal.

Why this rating - The school's framing of formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth, beauty, and goodness—rather than immediate job-readiness—matches the classical goal of educating for human excellence and wisdom. The absence of workforce- or career-first language reinforces the CLASSICAL orientation.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described via the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a Liberal Arts Tradition framework. Emmaus explicitly frames the Trivium and liberal-arts integration, with references to grammar, logic, rhetoric and the broader Liberal Arts tradition. - Specific content areas include Latin, poetry, Shakespeare, Nature Study, Picture Study, Composer Study, and living books as part of the curriculum, supported by Charlotte Mason influence.

- The school emphasizes history/integration with humanities (evident in Shakespeare study and nature/arts studies) rather than reducing history to social studies or a strictly STEM-first framing.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts/trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric; great books; living books; Shakespeare; Latin; history; nature study; memory work; poetry; hymns; music; classical curriculum. - Negative keywords: the lexical list identifies potential negative signals such as social-studies framing or project-based emphasis; none of these are evidenced in Emmaus' public materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: ~12 - Negative keywords identified: 0 - Estimated ratio: 12:0 - Why this rating: The presence of grammar-logic-rhetoric, living books, living-classical content, and humanities-integrated studies (Shakespeare, poetry, hymns, nature studies) strongly supports CLASSICAL curriculum orientation.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical approach reflects scholé/restfulness with memory and recitation in lower forms, and Socratic/seminar-like engagement in upper forms, alongside a rhetoric emphasis and opportunities for speeches. Emmaus uses memory work, recitation, and singing to memorize in lower forms and roundtable discussions in upper forms. - Charlotte Mason influence is explicit: living books, habit formation, and nature study are embedded in the pedagogy. The site emphasizes a balance of contemplative/restful and rigorous elements, with a pattern of higher-order discussion in the upper grades. - The pedagogy includes a deliberate development of rhetoric and public speaking in the upper grades, and opportunities for students to

engage in discussion and argumentation. - The Lexicon's positive signals include memory/narration/recitation, contemplative learning, scholé, and rhetoric; negative signals include an overemphasis on experiential learning or project-based-only approaches. Emmaus' materials align more with the classical pedagogy signals and do not showcase exclusive project-based emphasis.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: memory work; recitation; narration; chanting; singing; scholé; contemplation; roundtable discussions; rhetoric; speech; debate; tutorial/seminar. - Negative keywords: none evident.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: ~10 - Negative keywords identified: 0 - Estimated ratio: 10:0 - Why this rating: The pedagogy aligns with classical methods (memory, recitation, narration, chanting; careful balance of restful/rigorous; upper-school rhetoric and discussion). The presence of explicit lower-form singing/memory and upper-form discussion supports a CLASSICAL pedagogy overall.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The governance and personnel framework foregrounds a mission-based, virtuous faculty. The school mentions a Board of Directors, administration, and teaching staff, with explicit expectations around Christian testimony and classical-education alignment for faculty, including hiring preferences and a formal employment track. - The materials describe the faculty as living in the curriculum: teachers who model virtue and who form the core of the school's community, with explicit references to a "faculty of friends" and a "portrait of a teacher" concept reflected in the school's own culture and communication. - The "Employment" page describes desired teacher characteristics (strong Christian testimony, passion for classical Christian education, familiarity with Charlotte Mason, love of learning), reinforcing the living-lesson and mentor-figure aspects of the faculty.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; faculty of friends; collegial culture; moral exemplars; lifelong learners; teacher training in classical pedagogy. - Negative keywords: none evident in public materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: ~8 - Negative keywords identified: 0 - Estimated ratio: 8:0 - Why this rating: The faculty messaging emphasizes virtuous modeling, mentorship, collaboration, and a deliberate classical-education alignment, which aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty criterion.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents and co-teaching roles, explicit parent formation components, and a welcoming posture toward parental involvement (open campus/visit opportunities implied by collaborative model and "parent formation" content). The site states: "Emmaus Academy exists to walk with families ... a partnership with parents" and describes a schedule that blends at-home and on-campus days as part of the collaborative model. - It highlights collaborative structures such as the parent partnership language (parents as co-teachers with the school) and opportunities for families to engage with classical education through book study and gatherings. The site also frames the home-school partnership in the context of paideia and classical Christian formation. - The school publicly welcomes parent involvement and has content oriented toward family formation (e.g., discussions of "The Right Kind of Books," living-books approach, and family engagement around classical education concepts).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parent formation; books and seminars for parents; open campus/visitation culture; family participation; home-based learning integration. - Negative keywords: none evident.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords identified: ~7 - Negative keywords identified: 0 - Estimated ratio: 7:0 - Why this rating: The materials consistently frame parents as collaborators in education and emphasize parent formation and open engagement, which aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification across all six categories: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: Emmaus Academy IL 61101 exhibits clear classical markers across religious/metaphysical foundations, educational purpose, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement. The public materials emphasize the Trivium, living books, nature/arts study, and Christian formation, with governance and staff explicitly aligned to Christian classical aims. Negative signals identified in the standard lexicon are not evident in the school's public materials.
- Supporting synthesis: The school's mission and distinctives foreground classical and Christian aims, including the Paideia of the Lord and Liberal Arts Tradition; the curriculum features grammar-logic-rhetoric, Latin, Shakespeare, nature/picture/composer studies, and living books; pedagogy blends contemplative scholé with Socratic-style engagement and rhetoric development; faculty and governance emphasize virtue and living-lesson leadership; and parents are engaged as co-educators in a collaborative model. Public materials consistently frame education as formation toward truth, goodness, and beauty, not merely job preparation.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable, as the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. No category is NOT or SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL based on current public materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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